

Iconic Language

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Definitions and sources

Word iconicity is defined as the **resemblance between form and meaning** (e.g., buzz, crash, moo, ouch), “whether the specific sounds used to form a word carry any cue about its meaning,” to put it with Waugh (1994: 55). Contrary to a long-held view that words in a language are arbitrary, recent research has shown that languages “exhibit a balance between iconicity and arbitrariness” (Winter et al. 2017: 21). “Iconicity is an important property of all languages,” write Perry et al., “a widespread property of language” (Perry et al. 2015: 1, 2). Perry et al., in their study of some 600 English and Spanish words found that adjectives were rated as more iconic than nouns and interjections were highest in iconicity, followed by verbs and adjectives. With iconicity as typically related to a sensory domain (sight, sound, touch, taste and smell), auditory and tactile words tend to be more iconic than words denoting concepts related to taste, smell, and sight. Words that carry a concrete meaning, especially if related to the senses, are also more iconic than words with abstract meanings.

Harry Potter and iconic language

Maklakova et al. (2019) have shown how J. K. Rowling, in her *Harry Potter* books, carefully chooses her words for their sound (even in chapter titles), in a masterful use of alliteration, onomatopoeic expressions, iconic vocabulary. Maklakova et al. conclude (2019: 777): “Rowling’s novels are distinguished by aesthetic excellence in her employment of the entire arsenal of phonetic stylistic devices of the English language.”

Iconic language in the NLP Suite

Winer et al. (2024) csv file of iconic English word ratings (iconicity_ratings.csv) is stored in the iconicityLib subdirectory of the lib subdirectory of the NLP Suite installation folder.

- concretenessLib
- CoreNLP_enhanced_dependencies
- iconicityLib
- images
- namesGender
- sampleCharts
- sampleData
- sampleHeatmap
- sentimentLib
- wordLists
- LICENSE-NLP-Suite-1.0.txt
- release_version.txt

Name

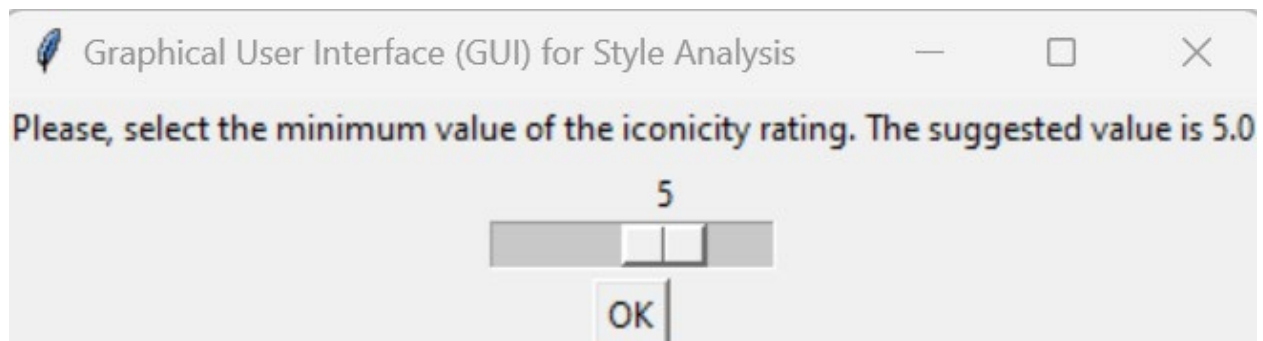
- iconicity_ratings.csv

The file contains nearly 15,000 English words that have been rated by multiple users for their iconic value. Each rated word is listed under the column “word,” the rating is under ‘rating’ (with values between 1 not iconic and 7 very iconic), and the rating standard deviation is under the column ‘rating_sd’). The standard deviation provides a measure of agreement over the rating of a word by the different raters. It is an important gauge of the reliability of the word’s rating.

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	word	n_ratings	n	prop_known	rating	rating_sd
2	aardvark	14	16	0.875	3.571429	1.827747
3	aback	10	11	0.909090909	3.7	1.418136
4	abandon	10	10	1	3.8	1.932184
5	abandone	10	10	1	4.2	1.549193
6	abase	10	11	0.909090909	2.5	2.068279
7	abash	11	12	0.916666667	3.545455	2.583162
8	abate	10	10	1	2.8	1.686548
9	abbey	10	11	0.909090909	2.4	1.646545
10	abdomen	11	11	1	3.272727	1.678744
11	abdomina	10	10	1	3.6	2.01108
12	abduct	10	10	1	4.1	2.13177
13	abduction	10	10	1	4.1	1.72884

The NLP Suite iconicity script provides a list in output of the most iconic words found in an input corpus. How do you define “most iconic words?” Probably **words with ratings > 5 and with raters’ agreement of standard deviation < 2**.

Users can enter the preferred minimum rating and maximum standard deviation values using a sliding scale.

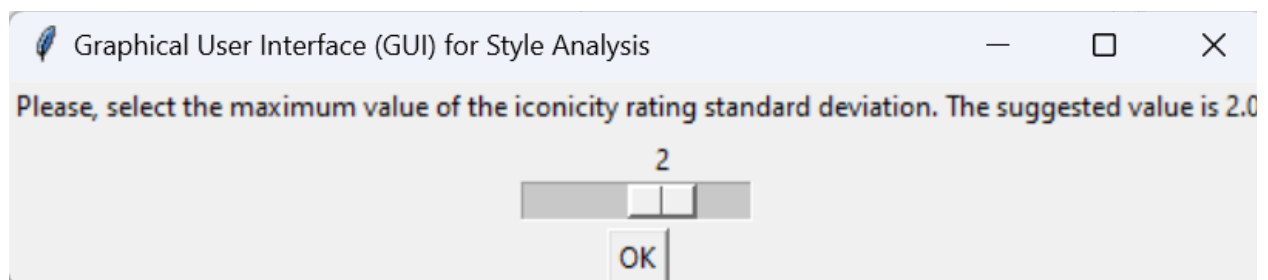


Graphical User Interface (GUI) for Style Analysis

Please, select the minimum value of the iconicity rating. The suggested value is 5.0

5

OK



Graphical User Interface (GUI) for Style Analysis

Please, select the maximum value of the iconicity rating standard deviation. The suggested value is 2.0

2

OK

References

- Maklakova, Natalia, Leona Grigoryeva, Elena Besedina, Ivan Maklakov. 2019. "Stylistic analysis of the phonetic texture of J. K. Rowling's novels." *Revista de Ciencias Humanas y Sociales*. Vol. 35, no. 22, pp. 777-790.
- Perry, Lynn K., Marcus Perlman, Gary Lupyan. "Iconicity in English and Spanish and Its Relation to Lexical Category and Age of Acquisition." *PLoS ONE*, 10(9): e0137147. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0137147
- Waugh, Linda R. 1994. "Degrees of iconicity in the lexicon." *Journal of Pragmatics*, Vol. 22, pp. 55-70.
- Winter, B., Lupyan, G., Perry, L.K., Dingemanse, M., and Perlman, M. 2024. "Iconicity ratings for 14,000+ English words." *Behavioral Research Methods*, Vol. 56, pp. 1640–1655. <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13428-023-02112-6>
- Winter, B., Perlman, M., Perry, L., and Lupyan, G. 2017, "Which words are most iconic? Iconicity in English sensory words", *Interaction Studies*, vol. 18, no. 3, pp. 433–454. <https://doi.org/10.1075/is.18.3.07win>